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A NEW SCULPTURE THAT MOCKS CLIMATE TALKS AT COPENHAGEN

in China's emission levels—just a slowing down.

The US recalcitrance has spread like a virus to Europe which has also toned down the massive pledges that they had originally made. At one time Europe was talking about cutting their GHG levels by as much as 50 per cent by 2050. That is now toned down to a more modest 20 per cent by 2030 if the US is on board. The main reason is that Europe does not want to lose its competitive edge to its arch rival, the US, by introducing cuts that are certain to result in an increase in the cost of production. That is because renewable energy alternatives as compared to fossil fuels cost a lot more per KW in the short term that make it unviable. For a little while when oil prices shot up to \$160 a barrel, alternative fuels suddenly seemed promising. But with oil prices dropping to around \$70 a barrel—down to the good old times—expectations slumped.

Perhaps the single largest blow to climate change negotiations was the economic meltdown and the ongoing recession. Job security has become the number one priority. With developed nations trying to bring down the unemployment rates, there was no way they were willing to make the big changes in lifestyle or the restructuring of the economy that climate change measures demanded. So in the last two years they have all conspired to stall and defeat the Kyoto Protocol. Forming an umbrella group of rich nations, Australia, which has the dubious distinction of being the highest per capita emitter of GHGs, had for years refused to join protocol. When Kevin Rudd became premier, he did ratify it finally but since then Australia has been working to destroy the tenets of protocol.

Before Copenhagen, Australia had floated a proposal that tried to blur the distinction between developed coun-

tries and the developing ones when it came to taking on commitments. The Kyoto Protocol recognised that industrialised countries had historical responsibilities to take on for having pumped tonnes of GHGs into the atmosphere in the past two centuries. These countries, therefore, not only had to cut their emissions but also pay to help developing countries take on mitigation and adaptation measures. China and the G-77 countries, including India, saw the proposal as a devious attempt to unravel the entire protocol so that it would have to be negotiated afresh. They promptly put their foot down.

Meanwhile developed countries made an effort to break the unity of the G-77 by offering finance to the more needy ones, especially island nations like Maldives that are under threat. To stall China and India, who had gained the largest amount from projects under the Clean Development Mechanism, they also said that offsets would now be more for the preservation of forests. So a fund for Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Forest Degradation (REDD) was floated that would help compensate countries like Brazil and Indonesia for preserving their forests instead of felling them.

Having failed to browbeat developing countries into softening their stand, developed countries are now pushing for a Danish proposal that would see only a political agreement emerging from Copenhagen. Termed 'Pledge and Review', it is already being viewed by the G-77 and China as a new ploy to destroy some of the key provisions in the Kyoto Protocol and lay the template for an all new agreement. If there is a failure in Copenhagen to bring about a reasonable agreement, leaders would have to face the wrath of people from across the world. Especially industrialised countries which are now regarded as the Enemies of the Earth with their selfish and myopic stance. 2012 may be on us sooner than we think. ■